

iPod Shuffle 1GB

Very Desirable Indeed

The new iPod, christened 'Shuffle', is extremely chic, and makes for a great neck ornament. It features a circular button for Play and Pause, which also doubles up as Hold when pressed for three seconds. Press the same button thrice in succession and you are taken to the start of the playlist. The button is circled by a dial that sports the volume controls and the Next/Previous or FF/RW keys.

Three hidden LEDs lie just under the surface, and are only visible when lit. The two above the dial, green and amber, light up during various functions. Flipping the device over reveals a sliding switch that lets you switch it ON/OFF, and toggle the shuffle mode.

There is a small, pinhole-sized LED on the bottom that tells you the battery status when the battery button is pressed. Battery life is amazing—14 hours on a single charge!

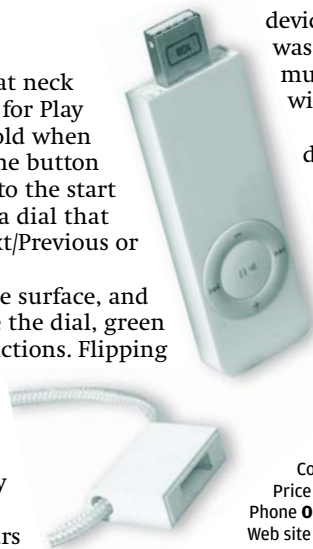
The Shuffle supports the MP3, MP3 VBR, WAV, AAC, and AA 2, 3 and 4. The sound quality is as impeccable as that of any of the larger iPods. It can be used as an external storage

device as well. However, transferring music using iTunes was slow—it took us about 10 minutes to transfer 1 GB of music. Also, transferring music to the device directly without iTunes doesn't work—the songs just don't play.

The Shuffle lacks a screen. It doesn't play FM, doesn't record voice, and does not support ID3 Tags.

Priced at just Rs 12,400, the Shuffle is a great buy. Lower capacity players, such as the Creative MuVo TX 256MB and Samsung

Yepp YP60 256 MB cost Rs 8,000 and Rs 16,000 respectively, and only offer the additional feature of FM and voice recording. If music is all you want, nothing beats the Shuffle.



Company **Apple India**
Price **Rs 12,400**
Phone **080-25550575**
Web site **www.apple.com**
Rating



iPod Photo 40 GB

Watch Playmates On This One!

The newest entrant in the hard disk-based MP3 players segment is the iPod Photo. It is essentially the regular iPod, with added photo-viewing functionality—hence the name.

The black-and-white screen makes way for a spanking new 220 x 176 screen capable of displaying 65K colours. You can also view your photos on a TV or a projector via the bundled AV cables.

The bundled iTunes 4.7 automatically converts popular image formats to its own proprietary format, and optimises them for viewing on a standard or widescreen TV. To Apple's credit, the images appeared crystal-clear on a 25-inch TV screen. The device displays 25 full-colour thumbnails of stored images. It can also synchronise automatically with albums created with iPhoto, Adobe Album 2.0 and Elements 3.0. However, once you have the images in your iPod Photo, you cannot play around with them in any way—rotating, panning, or even deleting directly from the device is not possible.

Considering the new colour display, we expected a significant drop in battery life, and were stunned to see that the battery life had actually been prolonged to a cool 15.5 hours on a single charge!

Though it is still a great music player, at the end of the day it all boils down to price. And at Rs 35,000+, Apple really is asking for the moon, considering that you can get full-fledged portable media players which do all that the iPod photo does.

However, there's one reason you might want to buy this piece of luxury: Playboy has come out with seriously hot content for the iPod photo, and has named the service iBod! Now we *really* wish the screen was a lot bigger!



Company **Apple India**
Price **Rs 36,000**
Phone **080-25550575**
Web site **www.apple.com**

Rating



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Mac Mini

It's small, resembles a lunch box, and costs as much as six years of school education. Take the more than Rs 30,000 base price of the mini, add the price of 256 MB of memory—\$75 or Rs 3,300—and the official "most affordable Mac ever" tag, while true, seems ludicrous.

The mini is obviously a "try me" for the PC crowd, a fact underlined by the missing monitor, keyboard, speakers, and mouse. The question then, is, should you pay a small fortune for a dip in the Mac OS X pool?

If your computer usage is bracketed by the tasks of word processing, Internet surfing, e-mailing, listening to MP3s and watching a movie occasionally—then yes, by all means add the mini to your tech collection. The hardware, once beefed up with 256 MB of additional RAM, is good enough to drive these tasks and the odd OpenGL game or two on a 23-inch LCD screen (we tested the mini on one). Mac OS X is a wonderful, user-friendly and mostly consistent OS to work with. If you have the cash and the missing hardware on hand, this Apple experience is indeed worth the price of the ticket.



Company **Apple India**
Price **Rs 32,300**
Phone **080-25550575**
Web site **www.apple.com**

Rating



1 Poor: Has serious drawbacks and needs improvement before it can be used for its target application. **2 Mediocre:** Does not live up to expectations, needs improvement in many areas. **3 Average:** Reasonably competent but nothing spectacular about the product. **4 Good:** A good buy, better than most products in its category. **5 Excellent:** A brilliant combination of price, performance and features - far beyond expectations.